

FHS Ethics: Realism and Antirealism

Readings

Required readings:

- Smith, Michael. 2013. "Moral Realism." In *The Blackwell Guide to Ethical Theory, Second Edition*, edited by Hugh LaFollette and Ingmar Persson. Oxford: Blackwell.
- Street, Sharon. 2006. "A Darwinian Dilemma for Realist Theories of Value." *Philosophical Studies* 127:109-166.
- Enoch, David. 2011. *Taking Morality Seriously*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Chapter 8, 'Disagreement.'

Optional readings:

- Mackie, John L. 1977. *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong*. Harmondsworth: Penguin. Chapter 1.
- Driver, Julia. 2006. "Ethics: The Fundamentals." In. Malden, Mass.: Blackwell. Chapter 1.
- Enoch, David. 2011. *Taking Morality Seriously*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Chapters 1, 6, 7.
- Dreier, James. 2006. "Moral Relativism and Moral Nihilism." In *The Oxford Handbook of Ethical Theory*, edited by David Copp, 240-264. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Past Year Questions

'Regardless of whether non-naturalists can answer epistemological or metaphysical challenges, they cannot explain why moral facts, so construed, would have any practical significance for anyone.' Is that right? Does it matter? [2024 I]

'In attempting to secure the advantages of realism without giving any hostages to scientific fortune, non-naturalist realism ends up nothing more than wishful thinking.' Is that right? [2024 II]

'Our basic evaluative attitudes are as influenced by natural selection as almost everything else about us. Influence by natural selection would have no tendency to track mind-independent moral truths. So if we are realists, we must be moral sceptics. Moral scepticism, though, is not a live option for us. So we must reject realism.' Is that argument sound? [2024 III]

Either

(a) Can non-naturalist moral realists give an adequate explanation of the supervenience of the moral on the non-moral?

Or

(b) 'If realism were true, then moral understanding would be nothing more than knowledge of facts. But moral understanding is more than knowledge of facts. So realism is false.' Is this a compelling argument? [2023]

'There are no objective moral values, but we should nevertheless pretend that they exist.'
Do you agree? [2022]

'If it is a fact that a certain action would be good, a fact that you might or might not apply in deliberation, then it seems to be an open question whether you should apply it. So moral realism does not correctly capture the relation between the deliberative process and the normative standards to which action is subject.' Is this argument against moral realism any good? [2021]

Can evolutionary debunking arguments in ethics be answered by appealing to evolutionary pressures that favour the capacity to make accurate moral judgments? [2021]

Families of theories

- Naturalistic Realism: Paradigmatically defined by utilitarianism
- Nonnaturalistic Realism: Enoch's Robust Realism, Moore's Realism
- Naturalistic Cognitivism (but subjectivist): subjectivism and relativism
- Noncognitivism (hence antirealists): all expressivists and quasi-realists
- Antirealists (but not noncognitivists): Constructivists (endorse the reality of morality but invokes a constructive function out of which morality is created), Error Theory

Part I: Realism vs Anti-realism

The basic debate: arguments for and against

- Smith, Michael. 2013. "Moral Realism." In *The Blackwell Guide to Ethical Theory, Second Edition*, edited by Hugh LaFollette and Ingmar Persson. Oxford: Blackwell.

Realism vs Nihilism vs Expressivism

- Realism
 - Moral claims are capable of being true or false
 - Some moral claims are nontrivially true (note: this is compatible with subjectivism)
- Nihilism
 - Moral claims are capable of being true
 - No moral claims are true (all moral claims are false): when we engage in moral talk and mention properties of rightness and wrongness as features an act could possess, we are in error
- Expressivism
 - Moral claims are not capable of being true or false
 - Unlike the error theorist, we do not think that moral talk even presupposes/purport that rightness or wrongness are features that an act could possess
- Relationship between nihilism and expressivism
 - Similarity: they both insist of a world that is value-free and so devoid of any moral nature
 - Difference: nihilism sees moral talk as wrongly presupposing that rightness and wrongness are features of acts, it demands a reform of moral practice → we cannot continue to assert falsehoods once we know them to be false, and the reason why we continue to engage in moral talk is for another kind of nonmoral reason (i.e. the expediency of such talk).
 - In contrast, expressivism holds that the value-free nature of the world has no such consequence → moral thought and talk can proceed happily in the knowledge that the world is value free because we never purported otherwise
- Two fundamental questions
 - Are moral sentences capable of being true or false
 - Are there any moral sentences which are nontrivially true

Minimal Moral Realism

- Initial difficulty of moral realism: too easy to be a moral realist
 - It seems to follow that I am a moral realist merely by having some sort of moral commitment: Suppose I am a competent user of English and say that “‘torturing babies is wrong’ is true”. This means that I think that moral

sentences like “torturing babies is wrong” is both capable of being true or false and that there exists at least one true moral sentence

- But this commitment to moral realism comes too cheaply and seems very unlikely
- What has gone wrong is that moral realism believe that the sentences we use when we make moral claims are capable of being true or false strictly speaking, while the competent user of English is engaging in loose talk; the expressivist holds that moral claims are only capable of being true or false loosely speaking
- Minimalist moral realism: arguments for
 - Minimalism: the role of words “true” and “false” is simply to enable us to register agreement and disagreement with what people say without having to repeat what they said to express agreement or disagreement
 - This means that all that there is to know about the meaning of the word “true” is that when “x” is a meaningful sentence of English, and when “‘x’ is true” is also a meaningful sentence of English, someone who said “‘x’ is true” could have simply disquoted and said “x” and have said the same thing → saying “‘Torturing babies is wrong’ is true” is the same as saying “Torturing babies is wrong” and so saying “‘Torturing babies is wrong’ is true” instead of saying “Torturing babies is wrong” is strictly speaking
 - Minimalist moral realist believe in three things
 - Sentences we use when we say that actions are right and wrong are true or false strictly speaking, rather than merely loosely speaking
 - Some of these sentences really are true
 - Strictly speaking, the meanings of the words “true” and “false” are fully explained by the minimalist’s story
 - Minimalism is a very cheap doctrine → if you have any moral commitments at all, you are a (minimal) moral realist
 - This eliminates nihilism and expressivism since almost everyone has moral commitments
- Objections to minimalism
 - Minimalism fails to tell us what it is about a sentence that is capable of truth or falsehood that makes it capable of truth and falsehood: not immediately clear the conditions needed to be satisfied by “x” for “‘x’ is true” to be a meaningful sentence
 - “Snow is white” and “‘Snow is white’ is true” are both meaningful sentences but “Hooray for the Chicago Bulls” and “‘Hooray for the Chicago Bulls’ is true” is not → we need an answer for what makes the first truth-apt and the second not

- The minimalist says that the answer lies in the purely syntactic structure of the sentence where they can be embedded as antecedents of conditionals while “Hooray for the Chicago Bulls” might not be
 - However, consider the sentence “If the troves are gyiring and gimbling in the wabe then I will watch them” looks like a well-formed sentence → in fact having “true” predicated of them looks well-formed but the sentence is still not truth-apt as they are nonsense, meaningless sentence
- Clearly, the sentence with such syntactic structure must be associated with patterns of usage that make it plain what information about the world people who use the words in those ways intend to convey when they use them → truth-apt sentences are capable of being true or false strictly speaking when their meanings are explained by reference to states of the world
 - The minimalist might respond that this assumes the only way to explain the meaning of sentences with the syntactic features of a truth-apt sentence is by reference to the states of the world about which those sentences can be used to convey information; but we might instead associate uses of those sentences with the expression of certain nonbelief states → for sentences about moral matters we explain their truth-aptness (meaning) by reference to the desires that constitute people’s belief about the moral matters that those sentences can be used to express (rather than with reference to the world)
- Smith highlights that minimal moral realism is just expressivism by another name → but instead of denying that moral sentences are truth-apt strictly speaking, minimal moral realism may hold that there are two ways to explain meaning of a truth-apt sentence: to tell a story about states of the world that the sentence can be used to convey information about (truth-apt strictly speaking) and the other is to tell an expressivist story (loosely speaking)
 - So minimal moral realism does not make any difference compared to the expressivist → for either minimal moral realism is committed to explaining the meanings of moral terms in terms of the features of the world about which they are used to convey information or they are committed to explaining the meanings of moral terms in terms of the desires that the use of such terms expressed

The internalism constraint

- We cannot give an account of the information about the world that the use of such moral terms is intended to convey

- First, moral views tell us something about people's disposition to action (saying it is good to donate money to charity cannot be accompanied by indifference to giving money to charity)
- Second, even if you were to act differently, this would reveal you to be a hypocrite and believe something else contrary to what you say
- In other words, there is an internal or necessary connection between the moral judgements we make and our motivations, placing a constraint on our actions
 - Someone who sincerely utters "Torturing babies is wrong" must be averse to torturing babies (and hence this acts as a constraint)
- Expressivism is motivated by this connection and argue that our moral beliefs must be constituted by people's desires, otherwise it does not seem likely that the proper use of moral sentences be constrained by the truth of internalism
 - After all, the use of sentences like "Snow is white" can be done sincerely no matter what pattern of desire and aversion these people have
 - Expressivist argue that we do not find the same pattern of possibilities in such sentences because the sentences like "Torturing babies is wrong" can only be used to give the content of a belief that is itself, in turn, constituted by a desire and it is not by reference to the states of the world about which they can be used to give information that we explain the meaning of moral sentences
 - Instead, we explain their meanings by reference to the desires that constitute the beliefs the contents of which such sentences can be used to express (mind-to-world fit): The proper role of "Torturing babies is wrong" is to express aversion to torturing babies
- I deny the internalism constraint
 - I wholeheartedly believe that climate change is bad and we ought to do something to stop it i.e. eating sustainably, not turning on the AC and using less electricity. But I think this is compatible with my constant usage of the AC at home and this isn't chalked up to weakness of the will or my lack of belief. Rather, it is the fact that I do not regard myself as a good person
 - The internalism constraint seems to cleanly apply to states of disapproval or desire → but moral statements need not cleanly map onto desire → most people believe that charity is good, but they need not actually donate
 - The internalist constraint applied to moral beliefs requires a hidden premise that the person believes he is good/moral

Against Realism: Street's Darwinian Dilemma

- Street, Sharon. 2006. "A Darwinian Dilemma for Realist Theories of Value." *Philosophical Studies* 127:109-166.

Overall argument

- Street argues that moral realism is untenable in light of our evolutionary origins, due to how selective pressures ensure that only a subset of people with similar attributes survive and thus influenced our current normative beliefs, combined with the observation that our current normative beliefs are heavily correlated with what we take to be normative truths.
- The moral realist can either say that evolution has no relation with us reaching normative truths (and hence has been *distortionary*) or that evolution has helped us reach normative truths.
- But Street claims that regardless of which route the moral realist takes, they are bound for either (i) untenable skepticism about whether we can know normative truths, or (ii) bad science by giving a poor explanation of how our evaluative beliefs emerge

First horn: Evolution has no relation with us reaching normative truths

- Street suggests that the realist may deny that there is any relation between normative truth and evolutionary forces influencing. In other words, the way in which our normative beliefs have developed with respect to evolutionary forces are independent of normative truths.
 - Evolution, then, plays a distortionary role in developing our evaluative beliefs – statisticians call this ‘noise’.
- At first pass, it may seem questionable why this poses any sort of problem for the moral realist.
 - After all, as Enoch points out moral realism is compatible with quite a strong sense of first-order moral skepticism i.e. that moral truths may be out there, but we humans simply do not have epistemic access to them. For all moral realism says is that there are mind-independent moral truths; it says nothing about whether we as human beings have any special access to these normative truths.
 - But Street highlights that there is a strong correlation between our current normative beliefs and what we may take to be normative truths.
- So, Street’s charge is best framed as an epistemic objection: In essence, the task of the moral realist is to explain this degree of correlation with a non-evolutionary explanation of how our normative beliefs develop. To say it is merely by chance is deeply unsatisfactory.
- The Kantian may find this rather easy to do – they point to rational reflection as a non-evolutionary way of reaching normative truths.
 - But Street points out that rational reflection, best characterised via a reflective equilibrium, is contingent on our initial evaluative beliefs which is influenced by evolution. It is not possible to stand apart from our empirical selves via reason, as Kant wrongly considers as possible.

- Here, Street argues that since our initial evaluative beliefs are ‘contaminated’ by evolution, our tool of reflection is equally contaminated.

Second horn: evolution helps us reach normative truths

- The second horn is for the realist to account for how our evolutionary forces help us reach our mind-independent moral truths.
 - The realist, then, intuitively commits themselves to a tracking account of evolution: namely, that evolutionary forces track normative truths because recognizing evaluative truths help us flourish.
- But Street says endorsing such an account is ‘bad science’ because it is a worse hypothesis than what she calls the ‘adaptive link account’. Broadly, this account says that our evaluative judgements got our ancestors to react to their circumstances in ways that promoted reproductive success in intuitive ways.
 - For instance, evolution makes us care for our children, not because it is true that “caring for your children is good”, but because it is simply reproductively advantageous to do so.
 - I don’t think that Street needed to show a better theory in order to prove how bad the tracking account seems to be – many moral truths, such as “we ought not to exploit the vulnerable”, is very obviously reproductively disadvantageous, especially in the natural world where the strong rule.
- Whatever the case, the point is that the tracking hypothesis is quite an empirically implausible hypothesis and does not meet the standards of scientific scrutiny.

Plausible Response: dismantling the second horn and an anthropological

- But both Enoch and Street fail to consider the anthropological or societal dimension of evolution – one selective force is the kind of society we partake in.
- On this anthropological line of argument, it seems at first pass that we may accept that democratic regimes are those that survive our selective forces. This is perhaps because democratic regimes select for the best leaders, or result in the best policies. Of course this is all speculation, but we can accept that there is some reason why democratic regimes survive more so than others, at least in modern times.
- The second aspect of this argument is the recognition of the way in which moral debates have progressed throughout human history. The biggest moral movements have been via the emancipation or suffrage of some oppressed group – the abolition of slavery, the fight for women’s rights, and more recently a recognition of the plight of the worker or persons with different sexual orientations. It is through such contestation between the dominant and oppressed groups that our normative beliefs push and pull and evolve.
- For what reason might we think that such contestation solves the epistemic problem of pushing us towards normative truth? We may borrow a line from Srinivasan – because African Americans, persons of racial or gender minorities are situated as

such, they have reliable moral sensitivities towards objective moral truths because they learn these concepts from “counterhegemonic political communities” and are situated in an epistemically privileged position to pierce through the “ideological distortion” in ways that members of dominant groups cannot.

- The reason then, that such moral beliefs have spread throughout society is that the emergence of democratic regimes via selective forces have allowed for such contestation, which in turn encourages the propagation of normative beliefs from the oppressed to the dominant group, as a way of resistance.
- The advantage of this view is clear: it embraces a new anthropological dimension of evolution, by explaining the correlation of our normative beliefs and normative truths via an indirect account of our evolutionary forces.
 - Namely, selective forces cause democratic regimes to survive, which in turn allow for the contestation of oppressed groups to propagate their normative beliefs which reliably track normative truths.
 - By taking a new dimension of evolution, it does not compete with Street’s own account of adaptive link evolution for her account does not consider societal behaviours, only individual ones.
 - Furthermore, because democratic regimes seem empirically expedient for survival/reproductive success, it is at least congenial with Street’s evolution-for-reproductive-advantage story and thus scientifically rigorous.
 - It also accounts for the fact that much of our moral progress has been concentrated in the last century or so, just as democratic regimes have spread throughout the world. In this way, we may explain how the selective forces have led our beliefs to converge with normative truths – it is open to the realist to accept it, and it is not fatal to the moral realist.

Against Realism: Disagreement

- Enoch, David. 2011. *Taking Morality Seriously*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Chapters 1, 6, 7.

The Problem of Disagreement as an explanatory challenge

- Argument:
 - There is deep, wide-ranging disagreement in moral matters (across countries and historical era, as well as within them)
 - Thought to be empirically obvious
 - What best explains such disagreement is that moral opinions do not reflect (with different successes) an objective, independent moral reality, but rather perspectives, cultures, ways of life or something of the sort
 - Intuition: harder for the realist to explain moral disagreement than it is for those rejecting realism → why is the moral truth hidden from so many people on so many matters

- Therefore, moral opinions do not reflect (with differing success) an objective, independent moral reality, but rather perspectives, cultures, ways of life, or something of the sort
- Enoch thinks that to say realism is not an epistemological thesis and that moral opinions do not reflect objective moral reality, but does not imply that the objective moral reality does not exist is too quick and comes at a high price of scepticism
- Three strategies
 - Denying the need for explanation: Enoch argues that given our cognitive shortcomings, agreement rather than disagreement is what calls for explanation, that disagreement is generally to be expected and agreement the surprising exception that cannot be accepted as brute
 - We take some facts to be brute → things that call for explanation are those that make a phenomenon explanatorily interesting → Enoch admits he has no satisfactory answer but suggests a sort of “surprising/expectation” definition
 - Denying moral disagreement: there is widespread disagreement on specific moral judgements but these disagreements need not be genuinely moral disagreement. People agree on moral principles, but disagree on accompanying scientific or metaphysical beliefs
 - Abortion: one might say that everyone agrees that innocent humans should not be killed, but what people disagree on is the metaphysical status of the foetus as something that is alive or human
 - Weaker claim: it shows that there is less disagreement than initially thought (not that there is no disagreement) → some disagreements in specific moral judgements are attributable to differences in non-moral beliefs rather than deep, genuinely moral disagreements
 - Enoch doesn't like this argument because it cannot be the whole story of disagreement: unlikely that if we get all our nonmoral facts right, all moral disagreement would disappear → teaching the tyrant about the physiology of pain and psychology of humiliation will not make him a member of the human rights community
 - Alternative Explanations: many moral matters are complex and people have cognitive shortcomings and to different degrees, and hence some are prone to making moral mistakes. We also let our interests influence our beliefs which come into conflict
 - Enoch notes that such alternative explanations are easy to come by
 - Special attention to the distorting effects of self-interests: consider Singer's assertion that we are obligated to give all our money to famine otherwise we're terrible people morally. There are huge psychological payoffs to denying this → it is typical of many moral debates to have so much at stake (one's status as a moral person) and

so false moral beliefs can be easily explained in terms of psychological payoffs

- Mackie was impressed with the phenomenon that our moral convictions seem to reflect our ways of life and not the other way around
- Furthermore, it explains not just the scope of moral disagreement, but also the difference between the scope of moral and other disagreement (that moral disagreement is much larger because our interests are at stake)
- Most moral disagreement is aligned with interests rather than against interests
- Holistic evaluation: whether we accept the alternative explanation or current explanation also depends on whether we accept robust realism or we already have antirealist commitments → so this limits the strength of the explanatory version of disagreement from forming a strong objection against robust realism

The problem of Disagreement: undermining the support agreement would have lent to realism

- Argument from agreement to realism
 - P1: In many discourses there is wide-ranging agreement about the truths central to the relevant discourse
 - P2: What best explains such wide-ranging agreement is that there are objective truths the discourse answers to, truths on which opinions gradually converge
 - C1: Therefore, there are objective truths the relevant discourse answers to
- Argument from disagreement
 - P3: We are justified in believing realism about a given discourse only if it can be supported by the argument from agreement to realism
 - P4: There is no wide-ranging agreement in moral matters
 - P5: Therefore the argument from agreement to realism does not support metaethical realism
 - C: Therefore, we are not justified in believing metaethical realism
- The argument relies on a more general claim about realist commitments to any discourse – not just moral discourse → argues that there are more disagreements specifically in moral discourse
- Response: hard to see how we can justify P3. Even if accept a broad epistemology in which one explanatory need could justify a commitment to realism about a discourse, we still have no reason to accept that agreement is the only phenomenon explanation of which can ground such a commitment

- We have grounds to reject such an epistemology in general: our reason to believe in Robust realism is not due to the role that normative truths, facts and properties may have in explaining agreement but rather on the role they play in our deliberation about what they do → deliberatively indispensable and there is no non-question begging reason to take explanatory but not deliberative indispensability seriously
- But even if P3 is false or unsupported, there may still be a weaker problem: the unavailability of the argument from agreement takes away from the plausibility of metaethical realism

The problem of Disagreement: absence of semantic access to denial of Robust Realism

- Two communities can use the word “wrong” differently in their own moral discourse → and this gives us reason to believe that the meaning of “wrong” is different in the context
- But need to prove that different uses of the words doesn’t just give reason to believe but makes it the case that the meaning of relevant words are different in two societies and it needs to be shown that this is not just a problem for contemporary naturalist realism and instead for realism in general
 - The realist can concede that “wrong” has different meanings in the two communities’ languages but still insist that abortions are universally, objectively wrong

The problem of Disagreement: from absence of a method to denial of robust realism

- Basic premise: in scientific disagreement, there is quite a settled method of how to resolve disagreement → underneath lies a deeper agreement about what findings support what theories and to what extent. This feature is missing in moral disagreement, and so runs much deeper than in the sciences because there is no deeper agreement underlying it
 - There is no method for deciding cases of moral disagreement
 - Therefore at least in cases of moral disagreement, there is no objective truth
- The conclusion is quite limited in scope and restricts itself to only parts of morality where there is controversy
- Rejecting the argument
 - The argument needs a verificationist premise to be deductive: that objective moral truth is necessarily decidable, that there can be no (moral) truth at which we can have no method of arriving → but no reason why anyone should accept this in general and about morality unless they are prepared to reject robust realism independently
- The real challenge is in there being no objective truth being the best available explanation for why there is no method for deciding cases of moral disagreement. This depends on how we interpret the first premise

- Clearly not that there is literally no method or no justified method (the latter begs the question). There are two candidates
- No method guaranteed to convince: the absence of a method guaranteed to eliminate disagreement does not deductively entail the denial of realism, which requires another premise that though people may be morally mistaken, they cannot be too mistaken such as to resist the moral truth when presented to them via a justified method.
 - Those morally mistaken might be unconvinced by justified methods for a number of reasons such as being too stupid or certain epistemological beliefs about which methods are justified
- No agreed method: if we accept this, this is just showing how a type of disagreement supports the denial of realism but this presupposes that disagreement (about a method) counts against realism → but this is not something an antirealist can take for granted
- The real problem is that disagreement persists even among the rational, and that moral disagreement is rationally irresolvable
 - There are possible cases of rationally irresolvable moral disagreement, where both parties are equally rational, guilty of no flaw of reasoning or some such
 - The fact that the premise begins with “possibility” means that it applies even to discourses that do not exemplify wide-ranging no-fault disagreements, so long as it is possible for them to do so.
 - The argument is thus not vulnerable to worries about whether there are actual genuine moral disagreements or these moral disagreements are nonmoral in nature
 - Therefore, at least in cases where such disagreement is possible, there is no objective fact of the matter
- The argument from rationally irresolvable disagreement requires less empirically because it doesn’t presuppose actual moral disagreement, but requires more normatively, by imposing a normative standard on what is rational
 - A Pro-Life and Pro-Choice activist must both be considered rational and meeting such a standard/not violating any requirements of rationality
- Problems with argument from rationally irresolvable disagreement
 - It must be shown that rationally irresolvable disagreement is possible with regard to every moral disagreement, or at least with regard to sufficiently many and important cases.
 - An account of what “rationally irresolvable disagreement” is is needed: Enoch thinks you can either get “for free” the premise or the transition from the premise to the conclusion
 - E.g. if one employs a liberal understanding of “rationally irresolvable” such that a disagreement is rationally irresolvable only if one of the

parties can be shown to be inconsistent, then the premise seems plausible but it's difficult to see how it supports the conclusion

- After all, there are many crazy but internally consistent views in physics, mathematics etc
- E.g. if one adopts a narrow view that it means completely flawless, then the premise cannot be supported without begging the question against the robust realist by assuming that neither of a pair of contradictory moral claims need to be false
- Premise basically asserts that moral disagreement is possible even in the absence of anything worth calling a cognitive shortcoming
- Transition from Premise to Conclusion
 - Epistemological to Metaphysical: the argument may be thought to fail because it proceeds from an epistemological premise to a metaphysical conclusion, ignoring the gap between justification and truth → shows at most that no moral belief is justified but not that none of it is true
 - But if it is the only reply, then realists are committed to an extreme form of moral scepticism that none of our beliefs are justified
 - Is agreement that important: not clear whether epistemic justification of our beliefs should be held hostage to rational agreement
 - We need to distinguish between the justificatory status of our beliefs and the dialectical effectiveness we can hope to achieve in convincing the sceptic → if this is true in the most general of epistemological contexts, it should be true in moral contexts (so rational irresolvability does not undermine the justificatory status of our relevant moral beliefs)
- Rejecting the Premise
 - The argument from possibility is motivated from actual disagreements: both parties that disagree on moral judgements seem rational in the relevant sense and so the explanation for the actual disagreement does not come from a sort of cognitive shortcoming
 - Enoch's reply: Imagine John and Jane of which you have high opinions of their intellectual abilities. They are engaged in complex calculations and you observe that they are very careful, doing what they can to avoid mistaken reasoning and slippages and they get different results
 - Here is an apparently rationally irresolvable mathematical disagreement and it seems clear we should not conclude that the disagreement really is rationally irresolvable but you should not accuse John or Jane of a cognitive shortcoming

- The explanation for this is due to our prior commitment to a realism about arithmetical calculations → calculations should admit a unique/single result
- This applies to other discourses where we are comfortable with a realist view of some kind → if John and Jane see different shapes of the same object, we should think that one of them is guilty of something calling a cognitive shortcoming
- But isn't Enoch defining rationality in terms of truth?
- Enoch's example: imagine that Dan and Dana disagree about abortion and that we have no independent evidence that either is guilty of a cognitive shortcoming. But shouldn't the very fact of disagreement be taken to be evidence that at least one of them is guilty of a cognitive shortcoming, if we have a prior commitment to realism
 - There is bound to be some difference between Dan's and Dana's psychologies in virtue of which they differ on the moral justifiability of abortion → should we call this difference a shortcoming? It depends primarily on whether we think of **moral and arithmetical facts as something out there to be noticed or missed** i.e. if we accept realism.
- Ultimately, to assume that it is possible for neither party is guilty of a cognitive shortcoming and yet disagrees on moral judgments is to beg the question against the realist → so it is not an independent objection to realism

Against Realism: Epistemology

What we want from the epistemological challenge

- Wrong ways of understanding the challenge
 - Access: if robust realism has nothing to say about the means by which some privileged epistemic status is secured for normative beliefs, she has to conclude that normative beliefs do not enjoy this privileged epistemic status
 - Not independent of justification, reliability and knowledge
 - Justification: how are normative beliefs justified (and is it possible for them to be justified)
 - Enoch: no special difficulties applying to normative beliefs, whether you are a coherentist or a foundationalist or an internalist/externalist about epistemic justification
 - Enoch: there is no satisfactory theory of justification so an argument against the epistemic justification of a normative belief may count against the theory of justification rather than the justificatory status of normative beliefs

- Reliability: Reliability may be thought necessary for justification and a special problem for normative beliefs
 - Enoch: a class of beliefs is reliable iff a sufficiently large portion of it is true → circular: by arguing that normative beliefs are unreliable, we have to either concede that (i) some normative beliefs can be true or (ii) there is no truth to be had
- Knowledge: realists often have to rely on some mysterious faculty to gain moral knowledge, otherwise committed to a very skeptical kind of realism
 - Enoch: we already dealt with justification and we are to assume that there are normative truths (to be a challenge to Robust Realism) and that normative judgements express beliefs. All that remains is an anti-Gettier clause that epistemologists have not resolved themselves
- The epistemological challenge as explaining correlation
 - Analogy: consider that Josh has many beliefs about a distant village in Nepal and that a very high proportion of the beliefs are true. We need to explain such a striking correlation i.e. a causal route from the Nepalese village to Josh, otherwise it would too miraculous to believe
 - Similar to Platonism in mathematics: mathematicians are remarkably good when it comes to their mathematical beliefs → striking correlation between the truth of p and when mathematicians believe in p . But mathematical Platonists cannot explain such a phenomenon since they believe that mathematical objects are causally inert → challenges the ontological status of mathematical objects
 - On the realist view of normativity, it cannot be that our normative judgements are causally or constitutively responsible for normative truths since the truths are supposed to be independent of judgement
 - Some realist views can explain this easily: when normative truths are reducible or identical with natural facts (hence are causally efficacious)

Solution

- The explanandum: the correlation that calls for explanation is not that striking since only some of our normative beliefs tend to be true and not all or even most
 - It also seems reasonable that some reasoning mechanisms can get our normative beliefs closer to the normative truths, so long as the starting points are not too far off
- Two ways to answer the correlation
 - $A > B$ or $B > A$: unavailable to the robust realist because (i) normative judgements cannot determine truth and (ii) we do not want to depend on some mysterious faculty or commit to naturalism
 - C affects both A and B
- Enoch's thesis: Survival is Good

- Assumption: survival (or whatever evolution aims at) is good (note: it is not of value because it is an evolutionary aim)
- Selective forces have shaped our normative judgements and beliefs with the aim of survival or reproductive success: given that these are largely good aims (aims that normative truths recommend), our normative beliefs have developed to be somewhat in line with the normative truths
- The causal influence of selective forces only directly “pushes” us in the direction of having evolutionarily beneficial beliefs, not necessarily true ones: but the two may be systematically related as we are the kind of creatures whose actions are motivated by our normative beliefs about how we should act
- In summary: survival is good, so behaving in ways that promote it is pro-tanto good. One efficient way of pushing us in that direction of acting in those ways is by pushing us to believe that it is good to act in those ways. And we have just seen that it is good so to act
 - The evolutionary aim causally shapes our evaluative beliefs but not our truths → it is related to them in some constitutive way (but perhaps not reducible to)
 - Note, we do not have to commit (like the naturalist does) to the fact that goodness is reducible to evolutionary facts → but we might have to explain this correlation?
 - Enoch on the fluke of evolutionary aims being good: fundamental normative truths are presumably necessary in a fairly strong sense, or at least so we are entitled to assume in the context of critically evaluating the epistemological challenge to realism. But in any case, the remaining miracle doesn’t place a large burden on the robust realist

For (Nonnaturalistic) Realism: Enoch’s Solution i.e. Robust Realism

Argument #1 (Towards metaethical objectivity): non-objectivist metaethical views have implausible normative/moral implications in cases of interpersonal disagreement and conflict – there must be something objectionably non-objectivist about response dependence and expressivist metaethical theories

- Fundamental moral principle of impartiality in deciding preference conflicts: each person is of equal moral worth
 - In disputes/conflicts, our preferences should count equally or a resolution should be fair in counting both equally (like flipping a coin)
 - Willing to step back and view the situation of a conflict between two persons, one of which just happens to be you
 - Blackburn argues that our passions and subjective attitudes give us powerful normative reasons to act – Enoch agrees but Blackburn’s intuition usually

holds true when these passions are asymmetric (i.e. when my friend experiences grief I ought to cover for him in his job) – what we look for is when grief afflicts both parties equally and personal grief gives rise to an interpersonal conflict

- However, impartial solutions do not work in moral disagreements
 - Suppose I think that eating animals is wrong and you think that eating animals is right – should we stand our ground or use an impartial solution like flipping a coin?
 - Using an impartial solution seems morally repugnant
 - Want to show that there are many sets of circumstances in which impartial solutions may hold for a mere-preference conflict, but no analogous principle would hold for one that is grounded in a factual or moral disagreement
- Argument against Subjectivism
 - (Caricaturised) Subjectivism: Moral judgements report simple preferences, ones that are exactly on par with a preference for playing tennis or for catching a movie
 - Argument
 - P1: Caricaturised Subjectivism (For Reductio)
 - P2: If Caricaturised Subjectivism is true, then interpersonal conflicts due to moral disagreements are really just interpersonal conflicts due to differences in mere preferences
 - P3: therefore, interpersonal conflicts due to moral disagreements are just interpersonal conflicts due to differences in mere preferences
 - P4: Impartiality, that is, roughly: when an interpersonal conflict (of a relevant kind) is a matter merely of preference, then an impartial, egalitarian solution is called for, and it is wrong to just stand one's ground
 - P5: Therefore, in cases of interpersonal conflict due to moral disagreement, an impartial, egalitarian solution is called for, and it is wrong to just stand one's ground
 - P6: However, in cases of interpersonal conflict due to moral disagreement, often an impartial solution is not called for, and it is permissible, and even required, to stand one's ground
 - C: Therefore, Caricaturised Subjectivism is false.
 - Concern #1: P6 is itself a moral statement and amounts to begging the question as the argument assumes P6 as a premise.
 - But this is just the concern that P6 may be rejected on normative grounds → all we need is a weaker existentially quantified claim that there are some cases of conflict due to moral disagreements in which standing one's ground is permissible and impartiality is wrong

- Concern #2: the Caricaturised Subjectivist can assume that all preferences are on par when it comes to IMPARTIALITY and cannot claim that the preferences to which he reduces morality are special in certain ways, special in ways that make a difference to the appropriate way of proceeding in cases of interpersonal conflict. The Subjectivist can then claim there is no generally appropriate way of proceeding in cases of interpersonal conflict grounded in preference → the appropriate way depends on the nature of the relevant preferences → some preferences require impartiality while others don't and morality is of the latter kind
 - This objection fails only because Caricaturised Subjectivism was defined as simple preferences → shows how caricaturised this version is and may not generalise to other kinds of subjectivism
- Generalising the argument to response-dependence
 - Response-dependence views invulnerable to the above
 - Social relativist position: moral judgements are reducible to judgements about social approval → when conjoined with impartiality, the fair way of adjudicating disagreements depends on whether the people are of the same society or not (former means it is a merely factual disagreement but latter then impartiality applies and the argument breaks through)
 - Generally, if the responses are necessarily shared by all, then a response dependence view of morality that only referred to those necessarily-shared responses would treat all moral disagreements in the same way a relativist position treats intra-social disagreements and conflicts
 - Furthermore, the subjectivist may deny the claim that moral preferences are on par with preferences about tennis etc
 - They are perfectly enter first-order normative discussions, but just that moral preferences are just preferences
 - What the subjectivist needs to do to escape the Reductio argument is a way of distinguishing in a normatively relevant way between the preferences involved in the tennis-or-movie case (where impartiality applies) and those to which morality is supposedly reduced (impartiality does not imply) and then between the (preference-reducible) moral views of two disagreeing parties
 - Basically say some preferences are more important than others and hence why be impartial among them i.e. morality as normatively special and not on par with the tennis-or-movie case
 - Why the response-dependence line of thought has a cost: impartiality rests on normative intuitions about equal moral significance of people and so of their responses, but causing-pain-to-a-dog seems to be a case where truth matters

- The response dependence cannot really say what the rationale for the distinction is like replies available to the objectivist
 - Best he can do is to insist on the normative intuitions themselves or on some intra-normative support for them: we do think it's morally wrong to stand one's ground for the movie-or-tennis case and not for the dog case → objectionably ad hoc
- Generalising to expressivism
 - Blackburn's quasi-realism (denies that his view is response-dependent) and can deliver things like moral beliefs, moral truths and objective moral truths
 - But the quasi-realist needs to believe that morality somehow depends on our attitudes and feelings
 - Committed to counterfactuals like "Had I approved of bullfighting, bullfighting would have been morally permissible"
 - If what explains certain moral truths is something about my emotions or reactions, and if my emotions are prima facie just as important as those of others, then it must be wrong to stand one's ground in cases of conflict → then impartiality will kick in
 - Blackburn's metaphor: choosing one's moral preferences over the other is like giving priority to a child over others
 - Even if Blackburn should insist on not saying anything about what explains moral truths, we can insist that at the most fundamental explanatory level, all there is in the vicinity of morality is people and their attitudes, and there is nothing more, which triggers impartiality

Argument #2 (Towards irreducibly normative truths): an ontology of irreducible normative truths is indispensable for our deliberation rather than indispensable to explaining phenomena

- Harman's antirealist Challenge: moral truths or facts are explanatorily redundant and have no reason to believe they exist
 - Harman argues that when we think "animal torture is wrong", this is best explained by psychological, sociological, historical etc facts about you → whether or not what the children are doing really is wrong is irrelevant → this is the best explanation of our immediate moral judgements
 - Since we can explain the relevant observation best without assuming the existence of the relevant purported irreducible moral fact, we have no reason to believe there such such irreducible moral facts
 - General argument:
 - No Explanatory Role Thesis: moral facts do not play an appropriate explanatory role

- Explanatory Requirement: playing an explanatory role is necessary for justified belief in the existence of a kind of fact
 - Hence, we are not justified in believing in moral facts
- Coping with the argument
 - Reject the No Explanatory Role Thesis by citing examples where normative facts play a role in explaining moral judgement → but these vindicate a naturalist realism which Enoch denies and also even if they do not play an explanatory role, it doesn't seem to compromise their respectability in any way
 - Reject the Explanatory Requirement: considering other kinds of indispensability that may be non-explanatory in nature and that are sufficient to justify ontological commitment
 - The proponent of the requirement must find a non-arbitrary way of distinguishing between explanatory and other kinds of indispensability i.e. that explanatory indispensability ought to be taken more seriously than other types
- Summary:
 - P1: If something is instrumentally indispensable to an intrinsically indispensable project, then we are justified (for that very reason) in believing that thing exists
 - P2: The deliberative project is intrinsically indispensable
 - P3: Irreducibly normative truths are instrumentally indispensable to the deliberative project
 - C: Therefore, we are epistemically justified in believing that there are irreducibly normative truths
- Enoch's solution: Deliberative Indispensability
 - Indispensability (Colyvan): If a scientific theory T1 quantifies over, say electrons, and T2 is the theory we get after eliminating all references to electrons from T1, and if T2 is all-things-considered at least as attractive as T1, then it seems clear that electrons are not instrumentally indispensable for our scientific project. The relevant criteria for attractiveness here is explanatory → an entity is explanatorily indispensable just in case it cannot be eliminated from our explanations without loss of explanatory attractiveness
 - Basic intuition: those things that are ineliminable from the theory → not clear what ineliminability is and no entity may be strictly ineliminable for any theory because it can be reformulated and reaxiomatised such that any given entity is eliminated
 - Not merely useful but theoretically indispensable to justify ontological commitment

- Not enabling indispensability either i.e. needing enough sleep to conduct scientific inquiry
- Enoch's generalisation of Colyvan's definition: something is instrumentally indispensable for a project just in case it cannot be eliminated without undermining whatever reason we had to engage in that project in the first place i.e. without defeating whatever reason we had to find that project attractive
 - Intuition: the project itself is indispensable for a reason, and if the only way to engage in it in a way that doesn't defeat that reason involves a commitment to an entity (or a fact, belief etc), then the respectability of the project confers respectability on that commitment.
 - Colyvan's condition is a particular instance of this condition with the project being a scientific one and the relevant criteria of attractiveness being explanatory
- Intrinsic indispensability: which projects are intrinsically indispensable
 - Something being instrumentally indispensable is insufficient to justify ontological commitment without restriction on the set of acceptable projects → believing in evil spirits may be indispensable for the project of sorcery, but this is no reason to believe in evil spirits
 - Enoch: some projects are rationally non-optional and they are such that disengaging from them is not a rationally acceptable option → a project is intrinsically dispensable if (and only if quite plausibly but not important) it is rationally non-optional in the relevant sense
 - Instances of Inference to the Best Explanation are justified then because they are arguments from indispensability to the explanatory project, which is rationally non-optional
 - Not clear what rationally non-optional is but Enoch says the deliberative project is at least as respectable as our scientific or explanatory projects
- Deliberation: our deliberative projects are intrinsically indispensable for deliberation seems a rationally non-optional project for us
 - We may be seen as essentially deliberative creatures
 - If it is instrumentally indispensable for the deliberative project that p, we are justified in believing p
- Deliberation and the instrumental indispensability of normative truths: irreducibly normative truths must be indispensable for deliberation
 - Challenge: desiderata seem to pull in opposite directions → the thicker one's account of deliberation – the more one is willing to build into it as necessary conditions – the more plausible it is that irreducibly normative truths are indispensable for deliberation, but

the less plausible it is that opting out of the deliberative project is not a rationally acceptable option

- Goal: an account of deliberation that is sufficiently thick to require irreducibly normative truths without losing plausibility of the claim that deliberation is rationally non-optional
- Motivation: when engaging in deliberation about whether to be a philosopher or a lawyer, all other questions serve to answer “All things considered, what makes best sense for me to do” and we assume these questions have answers (even if vague)
 - Not an arbitrary choice but it feels like making the right choice
- Deliberation is the process of trying to make the decision it makes most sense for one to make, and has a distinctive phenomenological feel
 - Not on par with merely choosing a brand of cereal in which you have no strong directions for either brand and thus choose arbitrarily
 - The phenomenological feel is similar to that of answering a factual question
- We may be able to pick in the face of known (or believed) absence of reasons but we cannot deliberate in the face of a believed absence of reasons
 - Knowing that there is no decision such that it makes most sense of us to make it, we cannot try to make the decision it makes most sense for us to make
 - Deliberation, unlike mere picking, is an attempt to eliminate arbitrariness by discovering (normative reasons), and it is impossible in a believed absence of such reasons to be discovered
- Hence, in deliberating we commit ourselves to there being normative reasons relevant to your deliberation
 - Does not entail an explicit belief
 - Analogy of a reasoner who routinely infers to the best explanation: she may not be a very reflective reasoner and so may not have any beliefs about which inductive inference rules are valid and why. But by routinely inferring to the best explanation, she commits herself to IBE being in some important way a good rule of inference. If she believes that IBE is not a good inference rule, she is being inconsistent: if you are deliberating you commit yourself to there being relevant reasons
 - No commitment in the case of mere pricing

- Objection: why aren't desires enough for deliberation and why do we need normative truths to settle deliberation when we are moved by desires
 - When you allow yourself to settle a deliberation by reference to a desire, you commit yourself to the judgement that your desire made the relevant action the one it makes most sense for you to perform
- No good alternatives and showing they cannot accommodate deliberations: only normative truths can answer the normative questions I ask myself in deliberation, nothing less than a normative truth suffices for deliberation
 - Against the Naturalist: normative truths required are super different from naturalist, not-obviously-normative facts and truths → chances of naturalist reduction seems low
 - Against the expressivist: the noncognitivist must agree that there is a sense in which all normativity is grounded in the attitudes she just happens to find herself with. Such views cannot eliminate the constitutive role in shaping normativity of these normatively arbitrary attitudes. Deliberation loses much of its appeal once normativity is viewed as dependent on our attitudes (cognitivist subjectivists do no better)
 - Against error theory: the argument from deliberative indispensability is most directly an argument against global metanormative error theory

Against Realism: Noncognitivist Challenge

The Noncognitivist Challenge: no moral facts and truth

- Modern expressivists say that nothing is added through moral predicates, only an attitude is expressed
 - When I say that "Tom donating to charity is good", nothing further is described or reported than Tom's donation, with a favourable attitude expressed → not truth-evaluable
 - "...is good" functions syntactically like any other predicate but only non-evaluative predicates ever manage to convey information
- Advantages
 - Coherent with naturalist view: need not commit to the existence of moral features or that moral features are reducible to natural features
 - Epistemology: Need not entangle themselves to explain the perception of a sui generis realm of moral facts (worry for nonnaturalists); naturalists are confronted with the problem on how we might gain knowledge of naturalistic reductions → if it is a posteriori identification of the sort that links water and H₂O, it is difficult to see how the empirically grounded methods of scientific discovery can be utilised to forge the central links between moral and descriptive properties
 - Motivation: Judgements are expressions of conative elements of our outlook → beliefs cannot motivate by themselves but moral judgements can motivate

Realism against Noncognitivism

- Truth talk
 - Want to say “infanticide is wrong” is true and the explanation of disagreement by attributing agents the presupposition that there is a right answer waiting to be discovered
 - Frege-Geach problem: we believe that moral argument can take the logical forms of other kinds of argument and sentential operators in moral sentences as truth functional
 - Expressivists must make sense of the sameness of meaning in asserted and unasserted contexts → otherwise, must credibly explain away the appearances of validity (the word “wrong” appears descriptive in an antecedent “If stealing is wrong” while the word “wrong” appears normative in “Stealing is wrong”)
 - Diversity of moral predicates: the cognitivist can easily say that words like “benevolence”, “generosity”, “kindness” are instances of describing things as good or bad and moral talk is shot through with description, attribution and predication
 - The noncognitivist will have difficulty translating the general formula “X deserves y” beyond approval and the description that “X got y” → there’s more involved in this since we can register approval in any number of cases where desert isn’t involved like “it’s nice that X got y”
- Moral error
 - We want to say it is possible to have mistakes in moral beliefs and outlooks which noncognitivists have difficulty accommodating
 - They may accommodate this in two ways: (i) moral error is not having a false belief but involve incoherence or (ii) involve a failure to satisfy some other standard meant to govern attitude formation
 - But this isn’t enough: practical attitudes are inconsistent if they counsel actions that are not jointly realisable → but why does this imply moral error?
 - When attitudes conflict, which one is in error? There is no higher order principle to adjudicate
- Normative Questions: what we should do cannot just depend on the attitudes we have → what we want to know is whether our attitudes are appropriate
 - Even if the expressivists says what we should do is that attitude most coherent with our other attitudes, the fundamental question of why is that the most appropriate remains
 - What we ought to do becomes arbitrary
- Irreducible Normativity: can attitudes that expressivists claim we have be understood in a non-normative way?

- Attribution of propositional attitudes is itself a normative endeavour: attributing such attitudes analytically commits one to normative claims and conceptually presupposes an understanding of normative vocabulary
 - E.g. to attribute to an agent a desire to lose weight and a belief that dieting is the only efficient way to do so, entails a commitment to the view that the agent ought to go on a diet. One can't sensibly make this sort of attribution without being committed this way
 - Circle: to see someone as holding a moral judgement, one must attribute to her some desire or favourable attitude. But to make such an attribution itself is to hold some normative commitment → analysis of normative language itself presupposes notions of normativity
 - Expressivists cannot make sense of ethical discourse without recourse to unreduced normativity
- Against the expressivists analysis itself: To say that someone ought to do X is to express a favourable attitude to do X. But favourable is itself a normative notion
 - Seemingly impossible
 - Expressivists must show that moral judgements are something other than beliefs → Smith: a belief that p tends to go out of existence in the presence of a perception with the content that not p, whereas a desire that p tends to endure, disposing the subject in that state to bring about p
 - But Smith has to normative concepts for his account to work: it is simply untrue that all beliefs will extinguish when it perceives not-p and desires sometimes do extinguish after a perception that their content is unrealised; rather, what Smith should say is that a belief that p ought to go out of existence in the presence of a perception with the content that not-p

Against Realism: Constructivist Challenge

Constructivism

- All forms of constructivism are cognitivist
- Subjectivist constructivism are those that take at least some of the actual and uncorrected attitudes of duly selected agents as determinative of moral truths → moral rightness is constructed from the actual agreements individuals make with one another
- Objectivist views (of constructivism) require some degree of idealisation for the attitudes and responses that go towards fixing truth
 - Like Rawls', Scanlon's contractualism and Korsgaard's Kantianism

- Moral truth is fashioned from the views that agents take from a perfectly informed and dispassionate standpoint (i.e. pure practical reason, behind the veil of ignorance, or perspective of looking to identify principles that would govern persons no one could reasonably reject)
- Virtues of the objectivist position: (i) capture the impartiality of the moral perspective, preserve the categorical nature of moral demands, and provide a plausible view of the nature of moral error (subjectivists on the other hand fix moral truth by uncorrected actual attitudes of individuals or groups)
- Both are not committed to a mind-independent reality of moral discourse

Problems faced by objectivist constructivism

- Moralisation of constraints: How might we select an idealised procedure without the aid of some substantive moral views
 - Having equal or full information, freedom from errors of reasoning and a neutral disposition toward the welfare of all individuals seem to be motivated from moral views
 - If constructivists highlight the advantages of their theory by showing how the resulting principles and our deepest moral convictions match up, then there is the worry that the constraints have been moralised
 - Variation of the Euthyphro dilemma: Either initial conditions of choice are moralised or they are not: if they are not, then there is no reason to expect that the principles that emerge from such a construction process will capture our deepest ethical convictions. If constructivists import moral constraints, then they effectively abandon constructivism because it acknowledges the existence of moral constraints that are conceptually and explanatorily prior to the edicts of the agents doing the construction, presupposing realism

Constructivist critiques against realism

- What makes moral judgments true: Realists don't have any general answer to this question but constructivists do by pointing to actual or idealised persons whose attitudes are responsible for fixing the truth.
 - They tend to use the following argument
 - (1) Laws require lawmakers
 - (2) Thus, if there are moral laws, then there must be moral lawmakers.
 - (3) These lawmakers are either us as we actually are, some idealised version of us or God
 - Reply: We can deny (1) because it is as plausible as the claim that all the laws of logic, mathematics, physics etc are themselves product of construction and so have to reject realism about every domain → essentially begs the question by embedding a constructivist assumption

- Explanatory advantage: constructivism can also explain why the correct moral standards are correct since they have a principled defence of the selection; the realist must say that the moral standards she favours are just correct
 - Reply: constructivists earn their explanatory gains only by having a more complicated story than the realist about the nature of moral truth – the account of the status of moral standards and facts is only as plausible as the explanatory story gets told. Moral realism is simpler because it does not introduce an additional mechanism
 - Reply: logical standards or physical laws don't have anything obvious that makes them true – they simply are true. Propositions in these domains are irreducible
 - May be vulnerable to the assumption that truths within ethics are as well established as those of logic or physics
 - But Landau is claiming that the very limited explanatory resources of realism are not something peculiar to its ethical manifestation
- Moral Rationalism: moral rationalism is the claim that moral obligations are or entail sound practical reasons for action. Subjectivist constructivists endorse realism because they conceive of moral judgements as essentially expressive of our commitments and think that our commitments invariably supply reasons for actions while objectivists endorse moral rationalism because they believe that correct moral judgements represent true propositions about the implications of our rational nature
 - The worry is that the realist cannot do this because realists qua realists do not explain the source of moral demands as issuing from one's personal commitments, one's rational nature or one's practical identities → moral standards that assign obligations are not essentially a product of agents and the content of general moral obligations is not conceptually constrained by the sorts of endorsements that agents make → if moral obligations are independent of our psychologies they may fail to motivate us
 - Fails to explain how moral obligations can be intrinsically reason giving
 - Reply 1: Other objectivist constructivism also fails (rational persons may not be reason giving to us)
 - Reply 2: Sometimes there is no good reason to abide by morality and hence denies that there is anything to be explained i.e. denying moral rationalism → making it a criterion of adequacy that a theory be able to generate a sound practical reason to obey every moral demand is to take too grand a view of morality's powers
 - Reply 3: endorse rationalism but argue that moral obligations invariably align with self interests and considerations of self-interest are intrinsically reason-giving and not constituted by some function of one's attitudes
 - Stance independence so crucial to realism is secured by this last condition and the rationalism is secured by the first and second

Part II: Naturalism vs Non-naturalism

- Smith, Michael. 2013. "Moral Realism." In *The Blackwell Guide to Ethical Theory, Second Edition*, edited by Hugh LaFollette and Ingmar Persson. Oxford: Blackwell.

Naturalistic Moral Realism: Overview

- Naturalism: the view that the world is entirely amenable to study through empirical science → the only features we have any reason to believe objects have are one and all naturalistic features (features which are themselves posits, or composites of posits, of empirical science)
 - Motivated by the success of empirical sciences in providing explanations of the world
 - Some think that if any form of moral realism is true, then it must be a form of naturalistic moral realism
- Naturalistic moral realism: not only that some of the sentences that we use to make moral claims are capable of being true and false (strictly speaking), and that some are true, but also what makes the true ones true are naturalistic features of the world → features amenable to understanding in scientific terms
 - I.e. we discover moral features either directly from observation or by inference from observation: moral beliefs must therefore have naturalistic contents for only so could they be made true by naturalistic features of the world
- Supervenience constraint: the moral features of acts supervene on their naturalistic features → two acts which are identical in all of their natural features must be alike in their moral features as well (we usually take this as true)
 - When we apply moral language such as "right", "wrong" or "obligatory" to acts, we are thus constrained to do so in the belief that the acts in question have some naturalistic features that warrants the ascription of moral language
 - We need an explanation for the way in which we are constrained to use moral words → core naturalist claim is that moral features are natural features
- The central difficulty facing the naturalist is to answer which natural features warrant the ascription of various moral features to acts
 - One example for the naturalistic feature of acts that warrants the ascription of rightness is utility maximisation → rightness is the natural feature of utility maximisation

Key Objection Against Naturalism: Open Question Argument

- AFC that rightness and some natural feature X (say utility maximisation) were indeed one and the same feature of acts. Then it would follow that "rightness" and "utility maximisation" are not analytically equivalent. But it is quite clear that "rightness"

and “utility maximisation” are not analytically equivalent, since if they were analytically equivalent, then the question “This act maximises utility, but is it right?” would have to be one whose answer is immediately obvious to anyone who understands the meanings of the words used, being equivalent to the question, “This act maximises utility, but does it maximise utility?” But the questions are not equivalent. We can, without self-contradiction, agree that an act maximises utility but deny that it is right and it follows that the question “This act maximises utility, but is it right?” is not a closed question but an open question

- Summarised form
 - P1: If X is good by definition, then the question "Is it true that X is good?" is meaningless
 - P2: The question "Is it true that X is good?" is not meaningless (i.e. it is an open question)
 - C: Hence, X and the good are not analytically equivalent
- If the Open Question Argument is sound, then it shows that rightness is not identical with any natural feature of acts at all, since we may substitute X with any natural feature
- Initial Problems with the Open Question Argument: motivated from the fact that nonnaturalistic moral realism seems forced by the Open Question Argument, but that most of such theories fail. So the move must be unsound
 - OQA entails Nihilism: argument succeeds in establishing the conceptual truth that we conceive of moral features as nonnaturalistic, and so succeeds in showing that our beliefs about which acts are right and wrong are one and all beliefs about nonnatural features possessed by acts, but went wrong in supposing that any such features are instantiated → nonnaturalism shows that non-natural features are nowhere instantiated in actuality and hence all our moral beliefs are false
 - OQA entails expressivism: OQA is a reductio of the very idea that there are moral features → the reason we cannot come by knowledge of the moral features of acts via an inference from knowledge of their naturalistic features is because that would require that there are two distinct ways the world could be – a naturalistic way and a moral way – which stand in logical relation to one another
 - But there is only one single naturalistic way the world can be → the claim that the world is a certain way morally is not true → the role of a moral claim is not to represent a world in a certain way but to express desires or aversions
- Open Question Argument applies to expressivism
 - If “Michael judges that torturing babies is wrong” and “Michael expresses his aversion to torturing babies” were analytically equivalent, then the question “Michael expresses his aversion to torturing babies but does he judge that

torturing babies is wrong?" would have to be one whose answer is immediately obvious to competent users of moral language. But the question is clearly not closed i.e. open (as we may hold the antecedent and reject the consequent without self-contradiction). So, the two statements are not analytically equivalent and do not pick out the same feature of the world

- The OQA seems to rule out too much: it rules out naturalistic realism, expressivism and nihilism
- Naturalistic Moral Realism and response to the Open Question Argument
 - Objection 1: a posteriori, not a priori truth
 - Deny the assumption that if "rightness" and some natural property X (maximising utility) were equivalent, it would have to be an a priori truth → can be a posteriori
 - For instance, "water" is not analytically or a priori equivalent to "H₂O" but empirical science teaches us that water is just H₂O → two terms can pick out the same feature of the world even if they are not a priori equivalent → a posteriori truth
 - Burden is to show how it could be an a posteriori truth that these terms do in fact pick out the same feature
 - The reason most naturalistic moral realists use is that the reason it is an a posteriori truth that rightness is the property of maximising utility is that we invoke moral terms to explain various empirical phenomena and then discover a posteriori that the maximisation of utility occupies the explanatory role
 - For example, they argue that since, contingently, right actions have certain effects – i.e. being causally responsible for a tendency towards social stability – so it follows that we can fix the reference of the term "right" via the description "the property of acts, whatever it is, that is causally responsible for their tendency toward social stability", we can investigate the acts with this effect → discover it is maximisation of utility which is a posteriori discovery
 - Analogy: since contingently red objects have certain effects – they cause objects to look red to normal perceivers under standard conditions – it follows that we can fix the reference of "redness" via the description "the property of objects, whatever it is, that causes them to look red to normal perceivers under standard conditions" → if we discover the feature that explains this is some reflective property A, then we conclude that redness is surface reflectance property A
 - Jackson's response: Consider the case of colours. Clearly, we do not think that the surface reflectance property A and red are equivalent by mere reflection

and it is something we discover a posteriori through empirical investigation. But in explaining how we come to make this discovery a posteriori, we do appeal to an a priori truth about redness

- We assume we can fix the reference of “redness” via the description “the property of objects, whatever it is, that causes them to look red to normal perceivers under the standard conditions” → this a priori claim is vulnerable to the open question argument
- We can consistently hold that an act has a property which is causally responsible for the tendency of acts toward social stability and hold an act is wrong (hence open question)
- Naturalistic moral realists must face head-on the claim that we can refute the claim that there is some naturalistic analytic of a priori equivalent for “rightness”
- Objection 2: Conceptual analysis is considering what the complex set of constraints on the use of the word being analysed is and whether or not this complex set is entailed by the proposed analysis
 - Need to think about conceptual analysis more broadly → there are all sorts of constraints on the way we use words and to establish the analytic equivalent of “x is red”, we try to come up with something that captures this complex set of constraints i.e. what “red” means that entails them
 - I.e. the constraint on the proper use of colour words is that we use them to pick out properties that cause us to have certain visual experiences; a constraint that we use them to pick out features that are more reliably detected in the daylight than in the dark, a constraint that people’s use of them is defective when their vision is impaired
 - We are to judge the success of conceptual analysis accordingly → not by obviousness or by whether the analysis is open to reasoned argument
 - Water and H₂O might be open to reasoned argument
 - Moore’s argument evidently fails to refute that “rightness” has a naturalistic analytic of a priori equivalent
 - Consider the claim that “rightness” is analytically equivalent to “the property of acts that is causally responsible for their tendency toward social stability”. It is irrelevant whether this is an open question or obvious → only relevant question is whether, on reflection, we think that this analysis entails the complex set of constraints on the way in which we use the word “right” → if it does, then it is analytically equivalent

- Makes clear the enormous task ahead of the naturalistic moral realists which is to give a naturalistic account of the contents of moral beliefs that entails the complex set of constraints on the way in which we use moral words

Nonnaturalistic Moral Realism: Overview

- Moore thinks that we ought to reject naturalism and admit a realm of extra, sui generis, non-natural properties into our ontology, which is simply goodness
 - This sui generis entities explain obligatoriness, rightness and wrongness
 - Moore believed that what made the sentence “torturing babies is wrong” were non-naturalistic states of the word that elude understanding in scientific terms
 - Beliefs about which acts are right and wrong are thus beliefs about the nonnatural features possessed by the states of affairs that are caused by acts
- Problems with Moore’s nonnaturalistic moral realism
 - Epistemic problem: we must explain how we come by knowledge of goodness
 - Moore has no explanation, and we cannot use observation or any of our standard faculties as a way to acquire moral knowledge, for any property knowable in that way is by definition naturalistic
 - Only way is to multiply our ontology and include a mysterious nonnatural observational faculty → but then Moore’s theory becomes deeply unparsimonious
 - The supervenience constraint: the nonnaturalistic moral realist must explain why there are not possible worlds in which goodness floats free of the natural properties with which it is coinstantiated in actuality
 - Perhaps in actuality, goodness is coinstantiated with the presence of happiness. But if goodness is a distinct feature, then why are there not possible worlds in which goodness is not coinstantiated with happiness? Moore had no explanation of why this possibility is ruled out
 - If natural properties are distinct from nonnatural properties, then we should be able to pull them apart modally. But this violates the supervenience constraint, and so we cannot pull them apart modally
 - Problem of moral motivation: it is unclear why anyone cares about the existence of a nonnatural feature, since we ordinarily suppose morality is a matter of great practical significance
 - Expressivism is tailor made to capture the idea of moral motivation, since the act of making moral judgements is precisely expressing our deepest cares and concerns
 - Nonnaturalists hold that when we make moral judgements, we are expressing our beliefs about the nonnatural properties possessed by

things → but if this is all we're doing, why do we care so deeply about morality? Why do we prefer the state of affairs with this nonnatural property to those that lack the property?

- Modern nonnaturalism (Scanlon and Parfit)
 - They suppose that goodness is not itself a nonnatural feature, but it is the property of having some natural feature that provides everyone with a reason to desire that that natural feature is instantiated.
 - Possible worlds are good to the extent that they have a natural feature, happiness, which provides everyone with a reason to desire that that feature is instantiated
 - This is nonnaturalistic moral realism because the reason relation itself is conceived of in entirely nonnaturalistic terms: the reason relation is not itself a relation that we can understand in terms amenable to science, but is rather a primitive normative relation
 - The reason relation is between facts and desires, and this reason relation must have some relation to the paradigmatic reason relation that holds between a fact and a belief (since we want to explain moral beliefs and their contents)
 - Like contractualism
 - Modern nonnaturalism can dispense with the supervenience constraint and the moral motivation problem in a very obvious way
 - But modern nonnaturalism still fall prey to the first epistemic problem: the reason relation holds not just between facts and desires, but also between facts and beliefs
 - In being committed to the irreducibility of the reason relation, modern nonnaturalistic moral realists thus commit themselves to the irreducibility of this relation even in the case of belief → but much of the epistemology seems to be an elaborate attempt to explain what this relation is in naturalistic terms
 - However, there is large disagreement among epistemologists about what the reason relation is in terms of belief
 - Hume: we should explain what it is for a fact to provide a reason for believing something in terms of an entailment relation that holds between that fact, on the one hand, and the truth of the thing believed, on the other
 - Others think that we should explain what the reason relation is in terms of raising probabilities or the concept of evidence
 - Underneath the disagreement lies a general consensus that some such reductive story can be told: the fact that certain facts provide reasons for believing things and others do not is not something that eludes understanding in scientific terms

- Bad news for nonnaturalistic moral realists: either reduce the concept of a reason for desiring itself to the concept of a reason for believing, thereby giving up their nonnaturalism, or admit that the central concept on which their theory is built, the concept of an irreducible reason relation that holds between a fact and a desire, itself bears no relation at all to the reason relation that holds between a fact and a belief

Specific Nonnaturalistic Moral Realism

See Enoch's argument for ontological commitment towards normative truths

Modern moral naturalism

- Externalist naturalistic moral realism: the view that though we can, by reflection find a naturalistic equivalent for the term "rightness", the naturalistic equivalent we come up with will leave it completely open whether someone who believes an act to be right will desire to perform that act, or be indifferent/averse to performing it.
 - Motivation: They do this because they treat moral facts like objective facts → they do not guarantee motivational force. This achieves mind-independence → if we allow the internalist constraint, then the judgement that "X is morally right" is necessarily linked to our desires and psychology
 - Burden 1: an explanation of why when we reflect on the way in which we use moral words, conclude that rightness has the naturalistic equivalent they posit
 - If we think the theory which holds that rightness is the property of acts that maximises utility, externalist realists must tell us what it is about the way in which we use moral words that is supposed to make this particular claim credible
 - The claim externalist realist make in the literature of moral explanation is that "rightness" is the term whose meaning is fixed by a causal explanatory theory which assigns rightness a certain characteristic explanatory role → rightness is thus like the word electron, where both serve to pick out a feature in virtue of the characteristic causal role that that feature occupies
 - Sayre-McCord's Problem: the explanatory role in question must be one that somehow guarantees the possibility of giving a justification for acting in the way that is deemed to be right → the fact that an action is right implies that there is some justification for performing it
 - But externalist realism makes this connection between a justification and an act being right altogether mysterious: there is an act that may maximise utility, but be one that there is no justification at all for anyone's performing

- Burden 2: must explain away the fact that many people have been inclined to think that our use of moral words is subject to the internalist constraint (common example is an amoralist who is perfectly rational but has no desire to act morally)
 - If we think that believing in an act to be right is to maximise utility, then why have so many people been inclined to think that possession of this belief requires a desire to perform such an act absent weakness of the will
 - It is surely an entirely contingent matter whether someone with such a belief will desire to perform such an act, whether they are depressed and weak of will or not. So how did so many philosophers get it wrong → some think violating the internalism constraint is a decisive reason to reject the theory
- Basic problem; the externalist realist must come up with an account of the explanatory role of rightness which makes the role connect in some constitutive way with the possibility of giving justification
- Internalist Naturalistic Moral Realism: we characterise rightness in terms of its distinctive explanatory role, but hold that the explanatory role of characteristic rightness is, broadly speaking, that of eliciting desire under certain idealised conditions of reflection
 - Smith's version: obligatoriness is the feature that we would desire our acts to possess if our desires formed a set that is maximally informed, coherent and unified. The internalist realist's claim is that this analysis of obligatoriness finds support in the way in which we use moral words. Saying that acting in a certain way in certain circumstances is obligatory, we thereby imply that there is some justification for our acting in that way in those circumstances. But the facts about what there is a justification for doing, in various circumstances, are in turn plausibly thought to be facts about what we would advise ourselves to do if we were better placed to give ourselves advice
 - These facts about what there is justification for doing are plausibly thought to be facts about what we would desire ourselves to do in those circumstances if our desires were immune to rational criticism
 - These desires are natural features of the world → almost like a rational desire utilitarianism
 - Explains why moral knowledge is a relatively a priori matter: if you equip people with a full description of the circumstances in which someone acts, they can figure out if it were a right, wrong, obligatory action etc
 - Objection from Relativism: who is the "we" referring to in "we would desire our acts to possess if our desires formed a set that is maximally informed, coherent and unified"

- Would we converge in desires if we were under idealised conditions of reflection? Or does it only include some subset of rational creatures? Are contingent and rationally optional culturally induced differences in our actual desires supposed to make convergence in the desires we would have under conditions of idealised reflection impossible (see Rosati's objection against rational desires)
- The second option gives us relativism (Harman) i.e. relativistic internalist naturalistic moral realism: when we say that actions of a certain sort are obligatory what we are really saying is a subset of rational creatures are such that they would desire that we act in that way if they had desires that formed a maximally informed, coherent and unified set → we thereby allow that other perfectly rational creatures may differ from us
 - If we believe that we would desire them too to act in that way under idealised conditions of reflection then of course we will believe that acting in that way would be obligatory for them too → simply having that their corresponding desires as part of their idealised desire set is no part of what makes our claim that it is obligatory for them so to act true
- Smith's version is nonrelativistic: their possession of such desires too is required for the truth of our claim
 - Depends on the substantive fact that there is a set of desires that we would converge upon if we had a set of desires that was maximally informed, coherent and unified → traditional rationalist project

Part III: Moral Nihilism and Relativism

Moral Nihilism (Error Theory)

Mackie's Error Theory

- Mackie's argument from Queerness
 - Two strands of argument: one metaphysical (questioning moral properties) and one epistemological (questioning our discernment of moral properties)
 - The arguments are not independent and the metaphysical strand is the load bearing argument, since the epistemological argument presupposes that moral properties are weird
 - Metaphysical: our conception of a moral property is essentially one of a very unusual kind of property, such that countenancing its instantiation requires us to posit in the world "qualities or relations of a very strange sort, utterly different from anything else in the universe"

- Epistemological: in order to track such weird properties we would need “some special faculty of moral perception or intuition, utterly different from our ordinary ways of knowing everything else”
- Mackie’s argument from Relativity
 - Mackie’s argument begins with an empirical observation: that there is an enormous amount of variation in moral views, and that moral disagreements are often characterized by an unusual degree of intractability.
 - Mackie argues that the best explanation of these phenomena is that moral judgments “reflect adherence to and participation in different ways of life”.
 - This, at least, is a better explanation than the hypothesis that there is a realm of objective moral facts to which some cultures have inferior epistemic access than others.
 - The example Mackie uses is of two cultures' divergent moral views regarding monogamy.
 - Is it really plausible that one culture enjoys access to the moral facts regarding marital arrangements whereas the other lacks that access? Isn't it much more likely that monogamy happened to develop in one culture but not in the other (for whatever cultural or anthropological reasons), and that the respective moral views emerged *as a result*?
- Opposition
 - Denying the premise: moral disagreement is not really as widespread as it is often made out to be, or at least arguing that much of the conspicuous disagreement masks extensive moral *agreement* at a deeper level (a level pertaining to more fundamental moral principles)
 - Denying the explanation: one might accept the phenomenon of moral disagreement at face value but deny that the best explanation of this favors the error theory
 - Relativism might be a better explanation

Moral Relativism

Dreier’s Moral Relativism (speaker-relativism)

- Relativism: moral statements are true or false only relative to some standard or other, and nothing is wrong or right simpliciter
 - Relativism and nihilism share ontology: both doctrines are skeptical about free standing moral facts, of some principles of action having a special authority that picks them out of the hodgepodge of conventions. Both see the moral feelings and social values of people and societies as constitutive of moral beliefs

- Relativism can be seen as a retreat made by common sense in the face of nihilism and hopes to salvage much of moral practice, thought and talk by relativising
- Relativism differs from nihilism by believing that there are moral properties, only that they are relative properties, while nihilists accept that there are such properties of “good-relative-to-utilitarianism” but they reject that these properties are called moral properties.
- Rejecting Absolutism
 - Accepts the nihilist rejection of freestanding moral properties: difficult to see how something could be good simply → what does it mean to possess goodness
 - If there were a special standard i.e. the right one, then something could be good absolutely by being good relative to that standard but we are not apt to resist the suggestion that good and bad are relative to the standard in question
 - Some cases have standards built into them
 - The standard that a clock that loses a minute each hour is not a good clock is uncontroversial and someone with another preference would be said to be mistaken → they have lost contact with the concept of a clock
 - Cases of kinds not defined by their function
 - Which stone is the best stone → unintelligible until we bring in some sort of standard
 - Rightness and Wrongness (relative to rules while goodness and badness are relative to standards)
 - Wittgenstein: we only understand the question of which road is the right road once a destination is specified, but only relative to the destination
 - Idea of restrictions: does the concept of morality come with some built-in rules that are uncontroversial like harming the innocent.
 - When someone has a “wrong” moral view, their deficit is not semantic: someone who thinks that rooks are permitted to move diagonally simply doesn’t know chess, but when someone thinks that killing the innocent is permissible, this view is not a matter of linguistic or conceptual incompetence
 - How to find set of rules
 - Possibility 1: many sets of moral rules and we can decide which things are wrong only relative to one or another of them → if this possibility is the most plausible, then relativism will also be a plausible account of moral rightness or goodness

- Possibility 2: no particular set of rules whose acceptance is constitutive of competence with the vocabulary or concepts of morality, but there are nevertheless considerations that will or would force all rational beings in the end to accept the same rules
 - Analogy: mathematicians debating an open conjecture → nobody thinks a number theorist who doubts the conjecture is incompetence in the language of arithmetic even if there is an undiscovered proof
 - There is a derivation of a certain system of moral rules from the basic precepts of rationality → morality might then be relative to that system of rules but still in some sense absolute → Dreier counts this as relativist but it's a "degenerate" version
- Arguments for Nihilism
 - Mackie's Queerness Argument and Relativity
 - Both of these arguments are about explanation
 - Mackie's point for the argument from relativity is that the best explanation for the diversity of moral views is a nihilist explanation
 - Diversity of scientific views over history can be explained by defects in observational capacity or mathematical tools
 - Diversity of moral views can be due to different customs, psychology and interests but never moral facts themselves
 - The argument from queerness is also IBE: moral properties are causally isolated which makes them queer, and do not enter the causal relations with the world we know
 - Harman's observation argument: Observation plays a role in science that it does not seem to play in ethics. The difference is that you need to make assumptions about certain physical facts to explain the occurrence of the observations that support a scientific theory, but you do not seem to need to make assumptions about any moral facts to explain the occurrence of...so called moral observations
 - When a physicist sees a vapor trail in a cloud chamber and observes "There goes a proton" vs when you see boys harming an innocent cat
 - Both observations are theory-laden and depend on certain background theory/moral views each holds → but we have no choice to mention the proton itself when we explain the physicist's observation but there are better alternative explanations with respect to moral properties
 - Harman thinks that this explanation is psychological: we refer to the plain, nonmoral features of the boys and the cats, and also the oral feelings and upbringing of the observer (you). → "The fact that you

made a particular moral observation when you did does not seem to be evidence about moral facts, only evidence about you and your moral sensibilities”

- Why explanation arguments do not apply to relative moral facts and properties
 - Evaluative and normative facts can comfortably fit into naturalistic explanations when they are relative to defined standards: standards for football teams have as their whole point to approve of teams with stable tendencies to win games, so one team's being better than another according to those standards quite naturally explains a victory
 - According to moral relativists, moral rightness and wrongness are also relative to standards and are fit to play the same sort of explanations that football team goodness play
 - Why: A is better than B relative to a standard S is itself a natural fact → there is nothing more to the fact that Patriots are a better football team than the Steelers (according to the standard for evaluating football teams) than the fact that their members have physical and mental abilities that give them the stable disposition to win a game against the Steelers under ordinary circumstances
 - Evaluative and normative claims reduce to natural or empirical ones once there is relativisation
- Relativism (indexical version)
 - The essence of relativism is that moral expressions are no different from other evaluative and normative expressions: they are incomplete and need a standard to complete them
 - The semantic value of a moral expression is a function that takes standards as its argument and returns determinate contents as its values
 - Consider the semantic values of indexicals like “me”, “yesterday” and “here” → according to the standard semantic for these terms, their meaning is a function from contexts (of utterance, inscription, or thoughts) to contents → ‘here’ is the function that takes any context to the place in that context, so that ‘here’ refers directly to the place in which it is uttered or written
 - The predicate “morally good” always picks out some property, but not necessarily the same properties in different contexts → it always picks out the property of meeting the relevant standards in the context to a high degree
 - Which standards: a relativist can say that the relevant standards are those of the speaker → when you say that abortion is morally wrong, you are adverting to your moral system
 - Advantages:

- Explains the connection between calling something wrong and the natural features of something that make it wrong
 - Moral properties are not a special sui generis property but it is some natural property i.e. the “wrong-making” property, and we need not some special story about why the natural property is identical to wrongness
 - Explains why moral judgement does not reduce to nonmoral judgement
 - Unless we know which day it is today, we cannot deduce from the date of an event whether it occurred yesterday
 - Similarly, the moral properties of an event do not follow analytically from its natural properties → moral judgement is always another judgement above and beyond naturalistic description
- Why we should not be against moral relativism
 - Argument 1 against moral relativism: almost seen as a bogey man and that “leading to moral relativism” is seen as an objection to a position
 - But no way to count against the theory
 - Argument 2 against moral relativism: moral relativists are not consistent (Bernard Williams)
 - “Right” means “right for a society”; “Right for a given society” is to be understood in a functionalist sense. Therefore it is wrong for people in one society to condemn, interfere with the, etc., values of another society
 - Wrong is to be understood absolutely rather than relatively as allowed by the premise → finds oneself with an absolute moral statement
 - Sharpening as modus tollens: if moral relativism is true, then so are the consequences of it being wrong for people to condemn others. But these consequences are not allowed by moral relativism. So, moral relativism is false
 - Replying against argument 2: rejecting premise 1
 - Are we to infer the principle of tolerance from relativism?
 - Missing a premise: we need to say something like “when evaluations are relative, let each follow her own” i.e. morality is merely a matter of taste
 - However, while the relativity of morality and taste might be the same, their subject matter is different as morality is about what to do → when I judge that artichokes taste bad, it does not make me commit to the judgement that you ought not to eat them
 - Dreier: seems unlikely that moral relativism itself has normative moral consequences about how we ought to litigate disagreements

- Internalist argument to nihilism or relativism (same as noncognitivist)
 - Weak internalist argument: it is part of our concept of moral judgement that a person does not count as sincerely accepting it unless she recognises it has having some reason-giving force
 - Nihilism
 - Moral goodness would have to be such that sincere judgement about it is intrinsically motivational. But there is no such property such that sincere judgement about it is intrinsically motivational. So there is no such thing as moral goodness
 - The second premise expresses a Humean conception of motivation but it is not uncontroversial, since there might be properties the mere cognition of which carries with it some motivational, reason-giving force.
 - However, the second premise need not deny that there exists properties with reason-giving force. What they deny instead is a very strong logical connection → for the second premise to be false, there would have to be a property whose apprehension would move any rational being as such and this apprehension would already have to be a motivational state
 - Humeans always deny that this connection: representation of the world as being this way (belief) is one thing, while motivation is another → for representation of the way the world is to make a difference in our deciding of what to do, it must be joined by some desire
 - What seems so queer about moral judgements is that it purports to be a representation of how things are while at the same time embodying an aim
 - Relativism
 - Moral goodness is such that sincere judgement about it intrinsically motivates. But, which properties motivate depends on the psychology of the judging agent. So which properties are the moral ones depends on the psychology of the agent
 - The mystery of intrinsic motivation is eliminated, if only we will understand that each person judges morally according to her own moral standards. And having moral standards is in part caring about things in a certain way
- Disagreement
 - The nihilist might reject the relativist due to the problem of disagreement
 - Consider moral statements A and B, where B can be changed to “not A”. But the relativists might think of A and B as containing an implicit relativisation that enables A and B to both be true at the same time

- Consider: I declare “prostitution is legally permitted” in Las Vegas over the phone, while my friend’s wife overhears this and asks “is prostitution legally permitted” who replies “prostitution is not legally permitted”, the implicit relativisation has removed the appearance of disagreement
- But we want to say that A and B disagree and this is because the linguistic intentions of speakers is often absolutist rather than relativist and so what they have said is *something that is false*
- But this does not undermine the relativist’s position
 - Speakers can have incorrect second order judgements while still having correct first order judgements
 - Consider: A policeman on the witness stand testifies that he saw the defendant walk out one hour later. The defense asks him to provide an inertial frame since the duration of one hour must be relative to one inertial frame. The policeman denies he meant any such thing and just “one hour”. The policeman’s intention was to name an absolute duration that is not recognised in relativistic physics. But this doesn’t impeach his testimony → the policeman’s judgement had a false presupposition behind it i.e. his conception of the world. But this doesn’t mean that his first-order judgement is mistaken → what the policeman said is true, only his background absolutist theory of it is mistaken

Harman’s Moral Relativism (a judgement that X is wrong is only in relation to an agreement or understanding)

- Inner Judgements
 - Harman argues that the moral “ought” is inherently relativistic
 - Suppose that a contented employee of Murder Inc was raised as a child to honour and respect members of the “family” but to have nothing but contempt for the rest of society and is sent to kill A. If we try to convince him that he should not kill A, he will be amused → it is a misuse of language that he ought not to kill A or that it would be wrong of him to do so
 - Suppose that Galactus came to eat earth – we may resist him or call him an enemy to be destroyed, but not that he ought not to eat earth
 - Sometimes, we use “ought” to in nonmoral cases
 - The employee “should” not have killed A is ambiguous: can be that it is a bad thing that they do so (normative “ought to be”) or that they are wrong to do so (moral “ought to do”) → only cares about the last
- Logical form of inner judgements

- Two characteristics: (i) imply an agent has reasons to do something, (ii) the speaker endorses these reasons and supposes that the audience also endorses them
- If someone says S that A (morally) ought to do D, S implies that A has reasons to do D and endorses these reasons
 - S implies that A has reasons to do D which S endorses, which Harman thinks lies in their goals, desires or intentions that S takes A to have and S approves A's having because S shares those goals, desires or intentions
 - So, if S says that (morally) A ought to do D, there are certain motivational attitudes M which S assumes are shared by S, A and S's audience
 - Assumes that the Kantian idea of motivation as lying in pure practical reasons (not desire) as wrong
- Harman argues that the shared motivational attitudes M are intentions to keep an agreement and inner moral judgements are made relative to such an agreement
 - When S makes the judgement that A ought to do D, S assumes that A intends to act in accordance with an agreement with S and S's audience also intend to observe
 - The source of reasons for doing D which S ascribes to A is A's sincere intention to observe a certain agreement
- Ought(A,D,C,M) is a four place predicate where A is an agent, D is a type of act, C is considerations and M is motivating attitudes
 - But sometimes the speaker makes a moral claim involving attitudes that a speaker does not share i.e. "As a Christian you ought to turn the other cheek; I however propose to strike back"
 - More precisely: "Ought(A,D,C,M) means that given A has motivating attitudes M and given C, D is the course of action for A that is supported by the best reasons
- Harman thinks that agreements are embedded within our moral discourse
 - As a society we tend to assign more moral weight towards harming than helping innocent people
 - Implicit agreement is reached through a process of mutual adjustment and implicit bargaining → relevant moral understanding is a result of bargaining
 - The explanation of why our morality takes it to be worse to harm someone than to refuse to help someone requires that we view our morality as an implicit agreement about what to do
 - Cannot be just about facts or an agreement in attitudes/principles (like agreement on utilitarianism)

- Much of our morality can be explained by giving a utilitarian explanation but also by saying that considerations of utility have influenced our implicit agreements
 - But any aspect of morality that is susceptible of a utilitarian explanation can be given an explanation of implicit agreement, but not vice versa
- Objections
 - When have we agreed: Harman argues that we have agreement in intention and agreement is not to be thought of as some sort of explicit ritual → agreement is in the relevant sense when each member of people has an intention on the assumption that others have the same intention
 - But constraints on how to act towards those outside the agreement since the agreement itself may contain such provisions
 - Why is it so hard to say what we have agreed on: it is often possible to recognise what is in accordance with the understanding and what would violate it without being able to specify the understanding in any general way
 - Furthermore, it is difficult to give a precise and systematic specification of any moral understanding because the understanding will not be constituted by absolute rules but will require specifying goals and areas of responsibility
 - Vague nature is alleviated in practice since one learns what can and cannot be done in various situations → expectations are adjusted to other expectations but moral disputes happen inevitably
 - What is believed to be right ≠/ what is actually right: Harman's thesis is instead that moral judgements make reference to and are made in relation to an agreement in intentions. Given that a group of people have agreed in this sense, there can still be disputes as to what agreement implies for various situations and Harman thinks that many moral disputes are of this sort

Appendix: Moral Cognitivism vs Non-cognitivism

Because Prof Storrs-Fox says we should also have moral cognitivism and non-cognitivism at the back of our mind, I will include some basic moral cognitivism and non-cognitivism debates.